

The Book of Lamentations: An Introduction

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Title, Authorship, and Date

The book itself—like many in the ancient world generally, and many in the Bible specifically—does not offer a title for itself. In English, of course, it is traditional to title the book “Lamentations,” and this commentary will continue that tradition, though it is worth noting here that the majority tradition within the Hebrew language is to call it “How” (איכה),² the first word of the book.³ An alternative ancient tradition is to call it “Lamentations” (קִינּוֹת).⁴ There apparently was a different ancient book, well-known at one time (2 Chr 35:25), entitled “Lamentations” (הַקִּינּוֹת), which unfortunately has not survived. The fact that Jeremiah contributed to, or wrote all of, that book might have contributed to the tradition that that prophet wrote the biblical book of Lamentations.

But, although there is a long tradition of ascribing the book to Jeremiah,⁵ the book itself does not say this, so the matter is open to debate.⁶ There are notable arguments both for and against Jeremianic authorship, a few of which will be mentioned here.

A common argument runs that roughly that the fall of Jerusalem was one of the central events of Jeremiah’s life, and so he would have been the natural author of a book about that event. Similarly, the openly emotional tone of the book of Jeremiah invites comparison to the distraught book of Lamentations. These points are valid so far as they go, but the fall of Jerusalem was pivotal to everyone living in that era, and the topic would have been emotional

¹ There is a substantial update to this translation dated to 2020, but, with all due respect to the publishing team there, I find that the update loses some of the distinguishing features of the 1995 version without gaining enough advantage in other areas.

² See the commentary on 1:1 for more on this.

³ Titling a book after the word, or the first not-too-common word, is a common strategy in Hebrew.

⁴ Mentioned in the Talmud and reflected in the Old Greek version and its daughter translations.

⁵ Most notably, in the Old Greek translation and in the Talmud.

⁶ This is especially so when it is considered that in the Hebrew Bible the book of Lamentations is positioned quite far apart from the book of Jeremiah, so the impression given by English-language Bibles that Lamentation is something of an appendix to Jeremiah is perhaps misleading.

for anyone with half a heart. Similarities of language are often noted, particularly references to the flowing of tears. But a look at the Hebrew discloses subtle differences as well (contrast Jer 14:17's עינה דמעה with Lam 1:16's עיני ירדה מים). On the other hand, איכה is relatively rare as an exclamation, but does occur in Jeremiah (48:17). Also, it has been noted that the spelling of the negative “no, not” as לוא is characteristic of Jeremiah (about half of the instances of this spelling are to be found in that book), and that לוא occurs in Lam 1:12. This is far from a decisive point in favor of Jeremianic authorship, but it is intriguing. A circumstantial argument is that use of the word בת of a city occurs (with the possible exceptions of Ps 9:14 [Hebrew 15] and 137:8)⁷ only in prophetic mouths (that is, in the mouths of men like Isaiah and Jeremiah), so perhaps Jeremiah is the author (though Ezekiel or Daniel could also be possibilities). Possibly the strongest argument for Jeremianic authorship is 3:14, which is reminiscent of Jer 20:7 and other passages both in language and in content.⁸

There are also arguments against Jeremianic authorship. For instance, “if Lam 4.19f. refers to the flight of Zedekiah and [his] entourage, described in 2 Kgs 25.4f., it would seem that the author was in the royal party, whereas Jer 38.28 implies that Jeremiah was in custody at the time” (Salters, 7). Perhaps “our, us” in Lam 4:19-20 means only that the nation as a whole was in a sense captured when its monarch was seized, but this observation does raise question marks over Jeremianic authorship. There is also the absence of the notably Jeremianic אנו in the book (contrast נחנו in 3:42⁹ and אנתנו in 5:7), though admittedly Jeremiah uses אנתנו as well. Jeremiah rarely uses אדני in reference to God (and when he does, it is usually in certain set phrases), while, for its small size, Lamentations does rather often. Lamentations twice (3:35, 28) uses עליון; Jeremiah never does. Jeremiah uses forms of אלהים dozens of times; Lamentations, never. The divine אל occurs in Lam 3:41, but in Jeremiah the term only occurs in a quotation (32:18) of Deuteronomy (10:17). But genre considerations could be at work here.

A special subcategory of the line of argument against Jeremianic authorship is the theory that the poems in the book have multiple authors. Writing in connection with Zech 7:1ff, Boda writes, “There is evidence of mourning rituals by inhabitants of the northern towns of Shechem, Shiloh, and Samaria associated with ‘the house of Yahweh’ in the wake of the fall of Judah in Jer. 41:5. The book of Lamentations and several psalms may provide evidence of the kinds of compositions used for such rituals in the wake of the fall of Jerusalem, as possibly also the later penitential prayers” (438). In a situation where there was regular and geographically diverse mourning for Jerusalem, multiple poems might have been written, and some of these might have been collected. Beyond this circumstantial evidence, there is the fact that the acrostic in chapter one has the letter sequence *ayin-pe* in vv16-17, but chapters two, three, and four use the sequence *pe-ayin* (2:16-17, 3:46-51, 4:16-17).¹⁰ Ancient abedecaries vary a bit in the

⁷ If David is counted as a prophet, the first example is not an exception, though it is a very early instance; the author of the second poem is unknown, but given its subject matter and placement near the end of the book of Psalms, the author is probably exilic or post-exilic.

⁸ Alternatively, if the speaker is meant to be a random sampling of Jerusalem's population, it could be another symptom of the turmoil within the city—any one person's plight evokes mockery, not sympathy. One of the saddest recurring themes of history is the ability of a people, when faced with external threat, to turn to internal bloodletting, fractured factions killing about as many as the enemy.

⁹ The significance of the use of this pronoun is partly reduced by the fact that it answers to the need of the acrostic.

¹⁰ One manuscript from Qumran has the same sequence in chapter one as is found in the following chapters, but this manuscript is not in my view a reliable enough one to follow on this point.

ordering of the letters of the alphabet.¹¹ It is hard to say, however, whether (1) different authors, products of different schools, wrote the poems in these chapters, or whether (2) the same author made use of a variety of letter sequences to meet the mood of the moment. The first possibility seems marginally more likely, but far from proven. Salters (7) suggests a comparison to the book of Psalms, a collection of separate pieces from various authors. However, a huge percentage of the psalms have a heading and/or a note on authorship,¹² and the book of Proverbs contains occasional headings noting authorship, while none of the five poems of Lamentations do. These poems have always been transmitted together, and never with any indication of multiple authorship. Also, three of the five poems (see 1:1, 2:1, and 4:1) start with the fairly rare exclamation *איכה*, suggesting one and the same poet.

To my mind the evidence is finely balanced. This commentary will refer to “the author,” “the poet,” etc., neither absolutely denying that Jeremiah wrote (either some or all) of the book, nor foreclosing the possibility that it is really a group of poets at work. Whoever the author(s) might be, the Holy Spirit guided the words to be what would shed light on the darkness of this present world (2 Pet 1:21).

The dating of the book is similarly uncertain. Clearly, it must postdate the fall of Jerusalem. Granting that poets can paint a vivid picture of past events, the tenor and phraseology of the book seems constantly to be that of an eyewitness to the horror. The closing lines of the book, too, seem to reflect a time before the days of Ezra and Nehemiah.

Genre

Quite a few passages in the Old Testament are lament, that is, an extended and often poetic description of sorrow at suffering.¹³ The entire book of Lamentations is composed in this genre.

This genre—at least in modern times, and at least in the modern West—caused discomfort and confusion for many. Wilson (24) catalogues some of the reasons for the difficulty of lament passages:

- “1. They contain strong outbursts of anger and vengeance directed at one’s enemies.
2. They include bold, seemingly irreverent, accusations pointed at God.
3. There is rarely an explicit explanation for the general movement within a lament from complaint to praise.
4. There is uncertainty over whether the laments constitute a failure of faith, or whether the courage to doubt and question should be viewed instead as a legitimate part of faith.
5. It is not clear how, if at all, these laments are to be models for us today, or incorporated into our liturgies and our personal prayers. This is essentially the question of how they function as Scripture today.
6. There is also a lack of clarity about whether laments still have a place after Christ’s victory in his death and resurrection, or whether they are no longer appropriate.”¹⁴

¹¹ Indeed, the Old Greek translation of Proverbs 31 reverses the order of the *ayin* and *pe* lines there.

¹² There is widespread debate among modern scholars as to whether the frequent *לדוד* means “written by David” or something like “dedicated to David” or “in the style of David.” I incline very much to the first view, but however one understands the term, it remains the case that Psalms has very frequent headings.

¹³ It is often stated that there is a specific meter (the *qinah*) in which laments are written, but it has been shown that that meter is not exclusive to this genre, even if there is a correlation.

¹⁴ Much in this list would also apply to the book of Psalms, and not only the lament sections of that book.

Much of this can be boiled down to two difficulties—two difficulties that are, in fact, intertwined: strong, even explosive, emotion is displayed; and the feelings expressed and pleas made do not easily fit into tidy theological categories. These things are difficulties partly, I imagine, due to inexperience—for, to speak very broadly, the experience of the global West after the end of the second world war has been of peace for the most part and a holding in check for the time being of the worst ravages of disease, plus a lack of epochal natural disasters—and, perhaps more to the point, a strong privileging of the intellect, an almost irresistible urge to have answers to any and every question that can readily be quantified or convincingly be tied to something in one's own experience. But there are some things in life—among them the fall of Jerusalem—that are so traumatizing as to defy dispassionate description, and some things which demand that we hand over to God our need to understand, even as he never let go of our sense of our need for him. Wilson contends that "lament is not primarily about venting feelings, for it is fundamentally a plea or petition for help" (Wilson, 244). I think "primarily" is an important qualifier there, but the point stands: the book of Lamentations is not emotional catharsis, but a supreme spiritual undertaking, a striving after the God of justice and of mercy, a God who seems to forget but always remembers.

That an entire book of the Bible is devoted to lament shows that expressing one's sorrow is an important thing for the believer. This includes the New Testament believer. True, Christ has come and on the cross and by his resurrection has defeated evil (Col 2:6-15). Yet he has been taken away from us for the time being, and so there is a place for fasting (Mat 9:15). A married couple might agree to forgo the sexual aspect of their love for each other for a time in order to pray (1 Cor 7:5). The blessing of Christ is on those who mourn (Mat 5:4).¹⁵

Sometimes Christians feel guilty for the feelings of frustration, intense sadness, revulsion, or cries of pain that they feel during their trials, as if these feelings showed a lack of joy, and hence a lack of obedience to the command to "rejoice always" (1 Thes 5:16). But we have been promised trials (Jm 1:2, 1 Pet 1:6, Ac 14:22), a trial is not a trial unless it is unpleasant. Even Jesus wept (Jn 11:35, Heb 5:7) and felt intense agony over upcoming trials (Lk 22:39-46, Jn 12:27).

So Christians facing trials, or considering those of others (Rom 12:15b), have every right weep. But those in the Christian those tears do not spring from a heart that views life's blows as random or irredeemable (Rom 8:20), and they are tears that will one day be wiped away by God himself (Rev 21:4). The tears are real, but temporary—this because Jesus wept, and died, for us.

Structure

The book of Lamentations is a series of poems (in modern editions of the Bible, conveniently divided into separate chapters¹⁶), each showing the classic features of ancient Hebrew poetry:

¹⁵ There is in the Church of the global West a growing recognition—as evidenced by some recently published books and by conversation with Christian friends—that lament has been neglected and needs teaching and exploration. Granting that the pendulum should not be allowed to swing too far—that is, that glib, materialistic attitudes should not be exchanged for unnecessarily dour, pessimistic frames of mind—this recognition is a good thing, especially if, as some suspect, significant persecution and suffering is not far off for Christians in the West.

¹⁶ There is a paragraph break in the Hebrew between 5:18 and 5:19, so it is possible that there are two separate poems in the final chapter. However, paragraph breaks in Hebrew sometimes mark key

brevity of expression, evocative language, frequent parallelism, frequent wordplay, and much artistry with the sounds and meaning of words in sequence. Of course, poetry survives translation into another language only partially, but the fact that the book is poetry should influence interpretation, and the unique power that poetry has to communicate should be free reign to direct the heart and the mind.

Another important structural observation is that the first four poems are acrostics,¹⁷ each stanza of the poem employing successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet.¹⁸ The reasons for this structuring device are debated. Many commentators have proposed that inasmuch as the entire alphabet is employed, a complete coverage of the topic is aimed at. For my part, I am skeptical of this explanation. Is there really nothing more that could have been said about the sorrow of war-stricken Jerusalem? And if each acrostic is meant to tell the whole story, why are there *four* of them? Others propose that the alphabetic structure aids in committing the poem to memory. This might be a factor, but there is a huge amount of poetry in the Bible, and arguably much of it—the psalms, for instance—was written with the hope that musicians, at least, would memorize it. “The most likely possibility is that the acrostic is simply an artistic device (like the sonnet in English literature)” (Salters, 20). Using this form well requires “skill and dexterity” (ibid., 21).¹⁹

A final structural observation is that chapter three is in several ways the heart of the book: in terms of structure, it sits exactly in the middle of the five poems of Lamentations; in terms of bulk, it devotes three lines to each letter of the alphabet, rather than one line only in the case of the other acrostic poems; and theologically, it has most to say about hope, not by way of blind optimism or with any dismissiveness of present pain, but because of the character of God. As a general rule, preachers ought to spend a good deal of time with this chapter, while not neglecting the others.

Themes

The trauma of judgment and war feels unbearable: This theme does not need illustration, pervading as it does the entire book. No one can rightly say that the Bible presents a one-sided view of things, with an entire book devoted to marital love and another devoted to sickening tragedy; one “heroes” filled with appalling defects, only one person being perfect.

moments or pronouncements to or about God, rather than simply separating distinct poems. Since the whole of chapter five uses the first person plural, it is probably a single composition.

¹⁷ There are other acrostics in the Old Testament, specifically psalms 9 and 10 as a unit (probably—there are quite a few textual difficulties and other obscurities there); psalms 25 and 37 (both depending, at least in part on some textual and other issues); psalm 34 (granting the anomalies of an absent *waw*-line and an additional *pe*-line at the end); psalms 111, 112, and 119; psalm 145 (depending, in part, on a textual variant); Pr 31:10-31; and Nah 1:1ff (granting that the prophet seems to use only the first half or so of the alphabet; he also possibly interweaves other material, doing so at greatest length in v1).

¹⁸ This is more achievable in Hebrew than in English, which has several letters with limited use, leaving a poet trying to do an acrostic like this with a frequent need to speak of xylophones and x-rays, zebras and zambonis. Hebrew has only one letter with a tiny number of words that start with it (*waw*), but this letter also serves as a conjunction prefix (“and,” “but,” “then,” “even,” etc.), so it is always possible to use it.

¹⁹ Morgan refers to the author of *Beowulf* giving a “virtuoso performance... where technique visibly but always unobjectionably reinforces feeling even at its strongest” (xxx). A similar, but more impressive, phenomenon is at work here, where the author of Lamentations does not abandon but rather makes full use of all the repertoire of ancient Hebrew poetry to convey the emotions of the disaster.

For Jerusalem, glory has gone: See, for example, 1:1, 4, 6-8, 2:6-7, 3:18, 4:1-13, 5:21. Part of what makes the situation so traumatic is the heights from which the city has fallen. “In the day of great anger, the Lord has shown no mercy even to his Temple” (2:2, NLT).

An ancillary discussion that at once illuminates complex translational issues and one of the leading themes of the book concerns the NLT rendering of *בת ציון* in 1:6 etc. as *beautiful Jerusalem*. The NLT paraphrases “Zion” (*ציון*) as “Jerusalem” (with a footnote alerting readers to the more literal translation), presumably because in English it is not usual practice to refer to the same person or place by means of multiple proper nouns,²⁰ so confusion could result. To judge from parallel cases (such as *בתולת ישראל*, “virgin {of} Israel” in various passages), the word *בת* (“daughter”) here is in the construct (hence “daughter of Jerusalem” in some translations, such as the ESV and NASB²¹), but, by common consensus of scholars of biblical Hebrew, this is a kind of apposition, so that the meaning is not “daughter of Zion [=Jerusalem],” but “Daughter Zion.” Similarly phraseology occurs elsewhere (especially in the prophetic books), such as *בת עמי* (“the daughter of my people” = “my people [pictured as God’s daughter]”) and *יושבת בת מצרים* (“the one who dwells in Egypt”). Since the pathos of visualizing Jerusalem as the daughter of a family is not readily apparent to the English ear, the NLT renders this phrase “beautiful Jerusalem.”

The sinner should not be sinned against: See, for example, 1:21-22, 3:52-66, 4:21-22. As much as sinful Jerusalem deserved judgment from God, it was wrong of her enemies—and supposed friends—to be so cruel. Wickedness toward a wicked person is still wicked.²²

Yahweh is both attacker and defender: See, for example, 1:5 with 11; 17 with 20; 2:1-8 with 18; 3:1-20 with 21-33; etc.²³ Inasmuch as the people have sinned against God, he is their judge; inasmuch the people have sinned against God, he alone may show them mercy. Inasmuch as he is a just God, he will act with severity; inasmuch as he is a merciful God, he can be counted on to show grace to the undeserving.²⁴

*God is to be reminded that things cannot continue as they are:*²⁵ See, for example, 1:11, 20ff, 2:18, 3:55ff, 5:1. The trauma of the evil that has befallen Jerusalem is unbearable—quite literally so, and so God who alone can bear all things must be entrusted with it.

Opening Shot and Closing Note

The first word of the first poem is one of despair (*איכה*). It is difficult to find an equivalent in English that doesn’t sound strange or contrived, so the NLT just lets the awful opening line

²⁰ Hebrew allows for more freedom in using multiple proper nouns with reference to the same person or place. In Lamentations, the reasons for the author’s choice of *ירושלים* in some cases and *ציון* in other cases are, I suspect, various, depending on the immediate context of each instance—subtly differing associations might be at work, the syllable structure of one term over another might fit metrical requirements, etc.

²¹ This includes—pun intended—the two daughter translations of the NASB95, NASB20 and the LSB.

²² The prophets Obadiah and Habakkuk contemplate this theme, under circumstances, as well.

²³ Conceptually related, I think, is 5:21—God is both returner and the one returned to.

²⁴ How all this works will only become clear (or, at any rate, clearer) in the pages of the New Testament.

²⁵ If this heading seems bold, it is because the book of Lamentations is bold.

speak for itself: “Jerusalem, once so full of people, is now deserted.” Bustling streets are empty, laughter and happiness replaced with hot tears of despair. Rulers go hungry and children go missing. A city that once had the world’s respect²⁶ is now treated with revulsion and derision. The shame to which Jerusalem has been exposed can hardly be overstated. This same word, with its despair, will run through much of the book (2:1, 4:1, v2)—so much so that its absence from chapters three (see the last paragraph under “Structure”) and five (the closing chapter of the book) are notable. Despair is the first word, but not the last.

Translators struggle with the last verse of the book (5:22).²⁷ Part of the difficulty is textual,²⁸ and part is translational. But details aside, the tone seems to be one of angst, bordering on despair. Indeed, many synagogues have traditionally repeated v21 after reading v22 in order to end on a positive note. Taken in context, the verse is not hopeless, but imparts a heart-rending, heart-searching, heart-broken urgency to the request of v21. On the one hand, the author would have to wait a long time for an answer to this request—decades for a return to the land of Israel, much longer for reconciliation between the heart of humanity and the heart of God. On the other hand, did the poet, writing these words, know—really *know*—what answering the request would cost God (Jn 3:16)?

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²⁶ One thinks particularly of the glory days of David and Solomon (2 Sam 8-10, 1 Ki 4-10).

²⁷ A select survey: NLT: Or have you utterly rejected us? / Are you angry with us still?"; NASB: "Unless You have utterly rejected us / And are exceedingly angry with us" (ESV similar); LSB: "Even if you have utterly rejected us / And are exceedingly angry with us"; Allen (157): "but you have rejected us outright / and are angry with us to an extreme degree"; Salter (241): "Even though you have truly rejected us / And been very angry with us"; Goldingay (208): "Even though you actually discarded us, / raged against us so much."

²⁸ I myself have adjusted my thinking as to the best evaluation of the textual evidence.